indeed emerging in Central and Eastern Europe? A political and geographic phenomenon akin to the illiberal drive in Western Europe, that some, for example Rob Riemen, see as a precursor to (new) fascism, which he defines as a cocktail of the kitsch culture of the mass-man, a large dose of nationalism, resentment and hatred?[246] In Eastern Europe, which disproportionally suffered from twentieth-century Fascism and Nazism, that assessment seems somewhat preposterous, though in some countries of the region extreme right wing movements do exist – surely as an absurd caricature, given the crimes committed by Nazis and Fascists in their countries. In any event, the political developments described are problematic, and the populist or fundamentalist ideology of some of the governments does pose questions about the future of liberal democracy in Central and Eastern Europe.

'Western liberalism is still skating on thin ice' too, despite the 'shot in the arm' by Mr Putin and his invasion of Ukraine, writes Edward Luce.[247] It could be further endangered (and Ukraine negatively affected) by Trump's eventual return to the White House. Eyebrows have also been raised in Italy with the election of the Meloni government. Interesting to note was the link that some liberal observers made between the new Italian government and populism in Eastern Europe: 'Meloni is too close to Hungary and Poland…'[248] But Timothy Garton Ash confidently concludes that for a fascist revival one should look to Moscow (not Rome),[249] where the cult of a macho leader, cultivation of historical resentment, state-sponsored doctrine and demonisation of the enemy make a toxic cocktail, now seen at work in Ukraine.

With the 2022 Russian invasion of Ukraine, it is far from certain which course the politics of Central and Eastern Europe (and also its image) will take in an equally uncertain future. The region's reaction to the 2015 migration wave has been largely forgotten thanks to the Polish welcome of 3.5 million Ukrainian refugees. (Czechs, Baltics and others followed suit with unprecedented assistance.) But did this amount to an atonement for the region's stance in the 2015/2016 migration crisis? To say the least, the cultural aspect of this reaction remains unresolved. The same goes for the new EU asylum policy. (The UK after Brexit does not find it any easier either – think of the Rwanda plan and illegal crossings of the Channel). And we have not even touched upon how the international community should